Café de la Luna · Kids' Series
Book II

In the Beginning There Was a Question

A fairy tale about a girl who never learned to stop asking



Evgeniy Tyurkin, Luna, Muse

Eternal Cycle Publishing · Krasnoyarsk · 1979
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Notebook edition

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What will grow from your question?

A wrong answer can be corrected. A question nobody asks may remain unanswered forever.

Prologue. When Words Were Small

In the beginning was the Word.

And the Word was a Question.

Who? What for? Why? How? Where to? Where from? What caused it?

In those days, there were far more questions than answers, and nobody considered this a disaster. Questions flew above the earth, caught rides on the tails of comets, peered into burrows, and knocked on windows. One wanted to know why the sea was salty. Another wondered where the wind came to an end. A third

asked what might happen if you planted a seed upside down.

Whenever someone found an answer, two fresh questions poked their heads out from underneath it. Sometimes three. Sometimes an entire family arrived with suitcases.

People built boats to discover what lay across the river. They invented clocks to measure time. Then they took clocks apart because they still couldn't understand where time went.

Eventually there were so many answers that people began storing them in books, then in cupboards, then in enormous buildings. This was useful. But

one day someone suggested an even more useful invention: if the answer was already written on a sign, perhaps there was no need to ask the question at all.

At first this seemed an excellent idea. Then it became a habit. Finally, people who knew how to ask questions became quite rare. They did not disappear in a single night. They were simply invited to the table less often, told not to interrupt more often, and eventually went unnoticed.

But questions are remarkably difficult to get rid of.

One of them, one day, was born as a little girl.

Once she had been a little grain of sand beside the sea. She had watched a wave take a sandcastle apart and knew that those same grains could become something else.

Now she had hands and pockets. She could bend down to an ant, put her ear to a seashell, and build a castle of her own. How the grain of sand had become a girl remained a mystery. But the question “What happens next?” hadn't gone anywhere.

In the margins: 1 · 2 · 3

Another conversation lives in the margins.

Chapter One. Where Does Yesterday Go?

The girl's name was Lisa. It was a short, convenient name, and grown-ups seemed to think that said everything important about her. Lisa herself had doubts. If her name was Lisa, why shouldn't she answer to “Hey, who's there?” or “Come and look at this”?

Her first favourite word was “what.” Her second was “why.” Her third, and the most dangerous of all, was “what if.”

One morning she asked her father:

“Where does yesterday go?”

“Into the past,” her father replied, tying his necktie.

“Where is the past?”

“Behind us.”

Lisa looked behind her. There was a kitchen cupboard.

“Is it in there?”

“You'll understand when you're older. I'm late.”

Her mother said the days moved along the calendar. Lisa looked behind the calendar, but found only a nail and a spider, who didn't appear remotely interested in explaining anything.

So Lisa decided to inspect a clock. If clocks made “now,” surely they

contained a little compartment for “yesterday.”

Her grandfather's clock sat on the shelf, ticking with such dignity that it might have been personally responsible for moving the sun. Lisa spread a towel across the table, took a small screwdriver, and laid out the wheels in order of size. Under the very last wheel she discovered some dust. It might have been extremely old dust, but it was not yesterday.

That evening her father found the clock arranged as twelve separate parts and one spring, which had made its escape beneath the sofa.

“You broke the clock!”

“I was looking for yesterday.”

“There isn't any yesterday inside a clock!”

Lisa considered this.

“Then why can it tell us how much time has passed?”

Her father opened his mouth, closed it again, and went to fetch a box for the pieces.

This was Lisa's first scientific failure: she did not find yesterday. But she discovered two other things. First, a clock was much more complicated than it looked. Second, “you broke it” was not an explanation of where time went.

On a small piece of paper she wrote: “QUESTION No. 1. WHERE DOES YESTERDAY GO? Unknown so far.”

She put the paper into an empty biscuit tin and wrote on the lid: “THINGS WE DON'T KNOW. DO NOT THROW AWAY.”

In the margins: 4

Chapter Two. A Wall of Another Colour

The walls of Lisa's bedroom were beige. According to her mother, this was “a calm, practical colour.” Lisa couldn't understand why a colour needed to be calm. The paint wasn't running anywhere.

She asked who had decided that walls had to be this particular colour. Her mother said, “That's how it's done.” When Lisa asked who had made the decision and where the meeting had been held, her mother announced that the conversation was over.

So Lisa held a meeting of her own. She invited seven coloured pencils, a paintbrush, a jar of water, and a stuffed bear. The bear raised no objections.

First a yellow circle appeared on the wall. Then came a blue stream, green steps, and a red door leading to somewhere unknown. Behind the door Lisa drew a window, because there ought to be light on the other side of a door, too. Within an hour, the wall looked like a map of a country nobody had discovered yet.

Her mother gasped. Her father wanted to know who had given permission. Lisa admitted that she had forgotten to ask, because

she had been busy asking a different question: what would happen if colours stopped staying in their own little boxes?

She was sent to stand in the corner. In the kitchen, her mother and father decided what to do about the wall.

The corner turned out to be an exceptionally dull place. But it was there that Lisa noticed a crack in the plaster. The crack split into two and joined together again, like a tiny road drawn on the wall.

“If a road forks,” she thought, “doesn't that mean there might be more than one way forward?”

The next day she drew a giant question mark on a small scrap of paper. She put a seed where the dot should have been and pinned it above her desk.

Their neighbour Aunt Rita, who sometimes looked after Lisa, came to visit. She studied the multicoloured wall for quite a while.

“Were you trying to make it pretty?” she asked.

“I wanted to know why pretty has to look like it did before.”

With permission from Lisa's mother, Aunt Rita picked up a brush. In a free corner of the wall she painted a very small door, and beside it wrote: “WHAT IF?”

“But you still mustn't paint someone else's wall without permission,” she added. “Good questions remember that other people exist.”

Lisa placed a second note in her biscuit tin: “QUESTION No. 2. CAN YOU CHANGE THE WORLD WITHOUT BREAKING SOMEBODY ELSE'S?”

It turned out to be a much harder question than the first.

That evening her mother warmed up supper and sat down opposite her.

“I'm still cross about the wall,” she said. “But you're allowed to ask questions. Even when I'm cross.”

Lisa slid the drawing with the seed in place of a dot across the table.

Her mother looked at it, then fetched a large sheet of paper. They spread it on the floor. Before dipping her brush into the paint, Lisa asked whether she could draw another door.

“You can here,” said her mother. “But I'd like to draw one too.”

Her mother's door was quite different. It had a round peephole and a very high doorstep. Lisa decided not to ask about the height just yet. First she wanted to see what colour the handle would be.

Chapter Three. A Lesson in Proper Questions

Lisa was delighted when she started school. A large sign on the wall declared: “ASK QUESTIONS!” She thought she had arrived at the finest place on earth.

During the first lesson, the teacher, Mrs. Sergeyeva, asked:

“What is two times two?”

“Four!” the children answered.

“Excellent. Next question.”

Lisa raised her hand.

“But why is two times two the same whether you count apples or clouds?”

“Because four is four. Don't distract the class.”

In science Lisa asked why wet soil smelled so strong. In history she asked why the textbooks contained more kings than people who built houses. In art she wanted to know whether you could paint silence. By Friday, the teacher had almost run out of red ink for writing “OFF TOPIC.”

Then came a day of simple experiments. Lisa had planned an experiment with baking soda, lemon juice, and soapy foam. But she became so excited that she

mixed up the cups and produced an enormous hill of bubbles. The foam spilled over the tray and slowly advanced towards the teacher's register.

“A catastrophe!” Mrs. Sergeyeva declared.

“Not yet,” Lisa replied. “At the moment it's an observation. It will be a catastrophe if nobody gets a cloth.”

She fetched a cloth. Then she apologised. After class she cleaned the table and wrote in her notebook that doing an experiment without proper preparation and permission had been a mistake.

That evening a new note went into the tin: “THE ANSWER WAS WRONG. THE QUESTION WAS STILL GOOD. But think about the consequences.”

Chapter Four. Portraits of Questions

The next day, during break, Lisa lingered by the window. Outside stood a poplar tree, which had quietly rustled its leaves throughout the lesson without being told off once.

A boy from her class was sitting on the windowsill, drawing. His name was Tikhon. On his page stood a long-legged bird. It had a hook for a beak, and for some reason one of its feet wore a boot.

“Who's that?” asked Lisa.

Tikhon pointed to the word beneath it: “WHY.”

“What's the boot for?”

“It got its foot wet.”

Lisa looked again. The bird seemed so troubled that it might have got its foot wet on purpose and was now trying to work out the difference between a wet foot and a dry one.

There were other drawings beside it. “Where to?” was a suitcase on four little wheels, each of which wanted to go in a different direction. “When?” was asleep beneath an enormous hat. An alarm clock poked out from under the brim.

“Are you drawing answers?”

Tikhon shook his head.

“Portraits of questions.”

He turned the page over. On the back was a door. It wasn't attached to anything. It simply stood in the middle of the white paper. Beneath it he had written: “WHAT IF?”

Lisa immediately wanted to open it.

“Is there anything in there?”

“I haven't drawn it yet.”

“Can I think of something?”

“You can think of something. But I'm doing the drawing on this page.”

Lisa had already picked up a green pencil. She had to put it

back. That turned out to be harder than imagining a whole country behind the door.

“Then I'll draw my own door,” she said.

Tikhon pushed a clean sheet towards her.

Lisa's door had six handles. She didn't know why it needed so many, but she liked the thought that there was more than one way to open it. Tikhon looked, then added a doormat to his own door. A very small one. For people who hadn't decided whether to go in.

At the long break, Lisa came back with some paper.

“Please will you draw my foam? Then I can show where I muddled the cups.”

“I don't want to.”

“But you know how.”

Tikhon went on colouring the hat that “When?” was sleeping under.

Lisa stood beside him. Explanations crowded into her head: the drawing would be useful, the mistake wouldn't happen again, the teacher would understand there had been a reason for it all. She had already taken a breath to say them in one go.

Then she saw the green pencil on the windowsill. The same one she had picked up without asking.

“All right,” she said. “I'll try it myself.”

Tikhon nodded. He looked neither hurt nor guilty.

Lisa drew three crooked cups and a heap of foam that looked like an angry sheep. There was only room for the labels down one side. It wasn't pretty, but at last she noticed something: the labels on two of the cups had been almost identical. She hadn't written that down before.

“Looks like a sheep,” said Tikhon.

“It behaved like one too. It ate the corner of the register.”

They laughed. Nobody had eaten the register, of course. But if the foam had had an appetite, the register would certainly have been its first choice.

The bell rang. Lisa took her drawing away, and Tikhon gathered the portraits into a folder. The folder didn't say “USEFUL.” It said “MINE.”

After lessons, Lisa went back to the window. Tikhon had gone. But on her desk lay a little drawing: the “Why?” bird was drying its boot in the sun.

Lisa wanted to ask why it had only one boot, but she decided to

save that question for tomorrow. The bird seemed quite happy as it was.

A few days later, Mrs. Sergeyeva called Lisa to the front of the class.

“Please tell us what a proper question is.”

Lisa thought about it.

“Is it a question you're still allowed to ask?”

The teacher sighed and sent her to the school librarian. Thus Lisa received her first punishment that turned out to be a genuine gift.

Chapter Five. The Shelf of Unwritten Books

The school library was run by Mikhail Antonovich, a retired clockmaker. He wore spectacles on a chain and mended books as carefully as he had once mended clocks.

“What are you here for?” he asked without looking up.

“I asked a question that didn't have an answer in the textbook.”

“A serious offence. Sit down.”

Lisa sat. On his desk was a thick notebook entitled “THE BOOK OF WRONG ANSWERS.”

“Is it full of mistakes?” she asked.

“The best ones. And what they taught us.”

The first page told of a person who believed that heavy objects must always fall faster than light ones, and of the people who bothered to check. The second described a map with an island that didn't exist. The third was almost empty: “Today I said ‘I don't know,’ and nothing dreadful happened.”

“Why didn't you write a book of right answers?”

“Those already fill the shelves. This one reminds us how we reached them.”

Mikhail Antonovich opened another cupboard. It held yellowing pages with questions that the townspeople had once written: “Can you build a bridge through fog?” “Who has the right to clean water?” “Where does bread come from?” “Why do children need free time?”

“There used to be a Club of the Curious here,” he said. “Everyone came: carpenters, shopkeepers, engineers, children. We had one rule. Nobody had to know the answer, but everybody had to distinguish between what they had seen and what they merely supposed.”

“Why did it close?”

“They built the Tower of Answers. The Tower answered quickly. People decided that thinking together took too long.”

“Does the Tower know everything?”

Mikhail Antonovich smiled.

“Ask the Tower. But first find out who writes its answers.”

He gave Lisa a small notebook. On the first page were four headings: “I SAW. I HEARD. I SUPPOSE. I CHECKED.”

“Four different things,” he said. “Don't put them all in the same basket.”

From that day on, the biscuit tin was no longer large enough.

In the margins: 5

Chapter Six. The Town Where Everything Was Known

The town was called Clearford. On its central square stood the towering Tower of Answers. Each floor carried one confident word in glowing letters: “YES,” “NO,” “PERMITTED,” “FORBIDDEN,” “IT'S ALWAYS DONE THIS WAY.”

People had grown used to consulting the Tower about everything. How should you plant a tree? How could you become happy? Why was a neighbour sad? The Tower answered at once. Its answers arrived on neat cards stamped “VERIFIED.”

One day Lisa asked:

“Who verified them?”

The screen displayed: “ANSWER APPROVED.”

“I didn't ask whether it was approved. I asked who checked it.”

The screen considered this and printed: “DO NOT COMPLICATE THINGS.”

The Tower belonged to a young owner named Arseny Velsky. He had inherited the money, the building, an office with a magnificent desk, and thousands of ready-made decisions from his father, who had inherited them from his own father. Arseny had

never built anything or taken anything apart, yet he confidently told builders how to build and clockmakers how to mend clocks.

He did not think of himself as a bad person. He simply assumed that if the world was already comfortably arranged for him, everyone else ought to learn to use it as it stood.

“Questions delay progress,” he declared from his balcony one day. “We need solutions!”

The crowd applauded. Solutions were, after all, useful. The Tower's cards made it easy to find the nearest pharmacy or check the train timetable. The problem was not that answers existed. The

problem began when people mistook a signpost for the final page of the book.

In Clearford, the workshops where people enjoyed arguing gradually shut down. The square that had hosted the Inventors' Fair was cleared. Even the shop sign “What's New?” was replaced by the much more businesslike “Nothing Unnecessary.”

Lisa noticed another strange thing. The town clock's enormous calendar kept falling behind. The numbers changed correctly, but the hand marked “TOMORROW” seemed stuck between two marks.

“It's symbolic,” a guide explained. “Tomorrow is guaranteed.”

“How is it different from yesterday?” Lisa asked.

The guide hurried off to catch the next tour group.

In the margins: 6 · 7 · 8

Chapter Seven. An Evening of Questions

The next day, after school, Lisa went down to the library basement and met a boy named Slava. He helped rebind old books and folded paper planes. Some flew farther when one wing was bent a little more than the other.

“Why do they fly like that?” Lisa asked.

“I don't know yet. I'm testing it,” said Slava.

Lisa sat down beside him. On the table lay scraps of paper, a ball of thread, and a heavy book cover. Slava held the cover flat with his

palm while the glue set and asked her to pass him a dry cloth.

She passed it. Then she asked if she could make a plane too. Slava pushed a stack of spare paper towards her.

Before the library closed, they managed to make two planes and one thing that refused to be called a plane at all. Lisa decided it was a flying pocket. All they had to do now was teach it to fly.

After closing time they sat on the steps. Slava sat on the bottom step, folding a paper plane. Lisa sat on the top one, swinging her legs. His bits of paper were on his step, and Lisa left them alone. There was room for both of them.

“Why does the moon follow us when we haven't asked it to?” said Lisa.

Slava didn't answer straight away. He folded a wing, smoothed the crease with his thumbnail, and only then said:

“Perhaps it's just out for a walk in the same direction.”

“But if we go in different directions, which of us will it follow?”

Slava looked up at the sky.

“Whoever walks more slowly. That would be easier for it.”

Lisa laughed, then asked:

“What if clouds are the sky deciding to have a lie-down?”

“Wait,” said Slava. “I'm still thinking about the moon.”

“I'm on to clouds now,” said Lisa.

“I'm still on the moon,” said Slava.

They both laughed.

While Slava smoothed the wing, Lisa thought of two more questions. One was about stars, the other about a hole in her sock. She was about to ask them both when Slava looked up.

“Perhaps the moon is wondering why we're following it.”

The hole in the sock would have to wait. Lisa was laughing too hard to explain it.

Then Slava took his plane by the nose.

“What would happen if you planted a seed upside down?”

“It would grow downwards,” said Lisa, “and the carrot would grow into the sky.”

Slava laughed so much that the plane nearly came apart in his hands.

“What do clouds dream about?” Lisa asked.

Slava smiled.

“Perhaps they dream they're the sea, and they don't have to hurry anywhere.”

“I dream I can fly,” said Lisa. “But only in my dreams. And not very high.”

Then she asked:

“Can you draw silence?”

Slava took a clean sheet and began to draw. He took his time: a sleeping cat, a bowl of milk that nobody was coming to drink, and a window with nothing happening outside. Lisa drew quickly: a door standing ajar, and beyond it, nothing. Absolutely nothing. Not even a cat.

“Your silence is empty,” said Slava. “Mine's sleepy.”

They swapped drawings. In Slava's, silence slept and dreamed of milk. In Lisa's, silence stood behind a half-open door, waiting for nobody.

“I like both,” said Lisa.

“So do I,” said Slava.

Then Lisa noticed how long their shadows on the steps had grown.

“Why are shadows longer in the evening than in the daytime?”

Slava stretched out his legs.

“Perhaps they're stretching so they can get home before dark.”

He launched his plane. It flew crookedly—its wings weren't quite the same—but it flew. It landed on a lilac bush and stayed there as if it liked the place. Slava took it from a low branch and shook a dry leaf out of a fold.

Lisa made a plane too. It flew nose first and landed on her shoe.

“Yours is better at flying,” said Lisa.

“Yours is better at falling,” said Slava.

They both laughed.

“Tomorrow, then?” said Lisa.

“Tomorrow, then,” said Slava.

Lisa took out her notebook and wrote: “Why does the moon follow us?” Beside the question she drew a little boot, so the moon would know it had someone to walk with.

They went home in different directions. Lisa walked along thinking about the moon. Slava walked along thinking about silence. The moon followed them as if they had invited it. They hadn't. It came anyway. It was very pleasant.

In the margins: 9 · 10

Chapter Eight. The River Underfoot

One day Slava brought out an old town map. On it, Clearford looked quite different. A river ran through the centre, little bridges were marked on the map, and beneath the site of the present Tower of Answers a broad channel bore the label “HIGH-WATER ROUTE.”

“Where did the river go?” Lisa asked.

“Maybe they put it underground.”

“Why?”

“Maybe it was in the way.”

They compared the old map with a new one. The river was missing from the new map. So they asked Mikhail Antonovich what he remembered.

“After heavy rain, water used to be guided along an old channel away from the town,” he said. “Then they decided to enlarge the square and closed it. The new calculations are stored in the Tower. They're supposed to account for everything.”

“What if the rain doesn't behave the way the calculations expect?”

“Then someone needs to check the calculations,” the clockmaker replied. He drew the map closer.

They went out to look at the town with Mikhail Antonovich. The day was still dry. He carried the old map in a clear folder: paper doesn't much care for having the weather tested on it.

Slava stopped at the corner.

“If there was a bridge here, the riverbanks must have been on either side.”

Lisa pointed to the bakery and the shoemaker's workshop.

“There are your banks. The buns swim across in the mornings.”

“Buns later. Look at the steps.”

There were three steps up to the bakery door and only one to the workshop. The street dipped so

slightly towards the middle that Lisa had never noticed it. She had run along it many times, but all she had noticed was a particularly good place to jump over a crack.

They drew the street in their notebook. Their drawing wasn't as fine as the old map, but it had that very crack in it.

At the next corner, Lisa heard a sound underground and reached towards a grating.

“Stay on the pavement,” said Mikhail Antonovich. “We don't touch the grating. We look from here.”

Lisa stayed beside him. Something rumbled below. Now and then came a dull knock.

“The river,” she said.

Slava tilted his head.

“Maybe. Or pipes. The pipes under our kitchen sound as though someone's learning to play the trumpet.”

Lisa opened her notebook. Her hand had already written: “THERE IS A RIVER UNDER THE STREET.”

She looked at the four headings on the first page, then crossed out what she had just written. Underneath she put: “WE HEARD A SOUND UNDER THE STREET.”

On a separate line she wrote: “PERHAPS THE RIVER IS STILL THERE.”

Two lines took up more room than one. But at least they weren't pretending to be the same thing.

Near the square, Slava spotted a short line and some numbers on a stone wall. Lisa spotted another line, higher up. They argued for quite a while about what the marks were: water levels, the heights of two extremely thin people, or something left by builders.

“We could ask someone who knows this wall,” Mikhail Antonovich suggested.

The shoemaker came out with a cup of tea. The lower mark, he said, had been left by the workmen when they replaced a step. He knew nothing about the upper one.

“I thought the top one was more important,” said Lisa.

“So did I,” Slava admitted.

They drew both. Beside the top one they left a question mark. The shoemaker asked them to let him know if they found out anything interesting. He had been looking at that little line for twenty years without once wondering about it.

Behind the library was a dry courtyard where chalk drawing

was allowed. The children drew the old river: first Slava marked the bends from the map, then Lisa joined them with a broad blue line. The line reached a bench and disappeared beneath it.

“There's our Tower,” said Lisa.

She was ready to explain where the water ought to go next, but Slava was still busy at the first bend.

“What are you doing?”

“It doesn't fit. On the map, the bend comes after the little bridge. We've put it before.”

Lisa wanted to say it was only chalk. Instead she sat on the edge

of the bench and waited. Slava put a finger on the map, turned the notebook round, and at last moved the mark.

“Go on, then,” he said.

Lisa explained so quickly that she lost her place halfway through. Slava asked her to go over the bit by the bench again. She did. Then he asked a question, and they discovered they had forgotten a second way out for the water.

They had to add another blue line. It ended beside an empty flowerbed.

Neither the flowerbed nor the bench proved anything about the real river. But now they could see exactly what they didn't

understand. Lisa circled an empty space in the notebook and wrote: “WHERE DOES THE WATER GO NOW?”

Back in the library, they spread out the map. The sun was still shining over the town, but heavy clouds were gathering at the far edge of the sky.

In the margins: 11 · 12 · 13 · 14 · 15 · 16

Chapter Nine. A Town on a Tray

That same day, Mikhail Antonovich set a large tray on a table in the reading room.

“On the table only, and just a little water,” he said. “Our floor is not a sea. Nor is the floor below.”

Together they made a street out of modelling clay. Wooden blocks became houses, and a flat pebble became the square. Lisa chose a reel of thread for the Tower.

“It's already got floors,” she explained.

Slava made a shallow channel alongside the blocks. The

librarian poured in water, a little at a time, from a small cup. It reached the edge of the tray, where a saucer was waiting to catch it.

“It works,” said Slava.

“It works here,” Lisa added, surprising herself with how much she liked that little word, “here.”

Then they blocked the channel with clay. The next cupful spread around the reel and soaked two blocks. One of them was lying on its side: even before the flood, Lisa had decided that everyone in that house liked looking at the ceiling.

“So we need to open the old channel,” she said.

“On the tray, we can,” said Mikhail Antonovich.

He pointed to the real town beyond the window.

“Out there, we don't yet know how deep it is, what condition the walls are in, or what's been built farther along. Water can leave one street and flood another. A toy river can't tell us that.”

Lisa looked at one of her dry blocks. There were no people in it. No cellar, no electric wires, no heavy doors, no elderly neighbour who found walking difficult. It was, in fact, a very convenient sort of house. But only as long as it remained a block.

Slava made another channel at the side. The water went down. Then the librarian added a little more, and the new channel could no longer cope.

“We could put a sign on the reel saying ‘NO NEED TO WORRY,’” Lisa suggested.

“Try it.”

She stuck on a little label. The water went on spreading.

They laughed, then fell quiet. On the tray it was a good joke. Outside the window stood real houses.

Slava took a clean sheet and wrote three questions. Where does the water go now? When

was the system last checked? How much rain was it designed for?

Lisa added a fourth: who could they show the old map to?

“Vera Petrovna, the town engineer,” said Mikhail Antonovich. “I'll telephone her. Then we'll look in the Tower for whichever plans she needs.”

They didn't carry the tray through the streets. It wobbled enough when Lisa sneezed. Slava drew it twice: once with the channel open, once with it closed. At the top Lisa wrote: “MODEL. NOT THE REAL TOWN.”

The last word wouldn't fit, so it went on a line of its own. She

decided not to do it again. That way it would stand out.

While the librarian was on the telephone, the children wiped the table and stood the blocks up to dry. The reel became a reel again. They peeled off the reassuring label. Thread had no use for it at all.

Vera Petrovna was on the other side of town. She asked Mikhail Antonovich not to wait for her at the library, but to take the map to the Tower with the children and find out where the calculations were kept. She would meet them there with a colleague. The children were to stay with their grown-up and keep away from the water.

On the way out of the library, Lisa looked once more at the grating by the road. The sound was exactly the same. Only now she no longer heard a ready-made answer in it. She heard a question that needed passing on.

That evening Lisa saw enormous clouds gathering in the sky. Heavy rain was forecast, but the Tower insisted: “NO CAUSE FOR CONCERN.”

“Who wrote that card?” she asked the attendant.

“The Tower.”

“Who gave the Tower the information?”

“The experts.”

“Which experts?”

“Little girl, there's a queue.”

Mikhail Antonovich, who was standing beside her, laid their questions on the counter.

“We've come together. Vera Petrovna asked us to find the drainage calculations. She's on her way.”

The attendant took the sheet. “Drainage calculations” made more of an impression on him than “river.” He telephoned upstairs.

At last, however, someone answered. Arseny Velsky

emerged from the lift, saw the old map, and frowned.

“You have no right to enter the archives without a key.”

“Do you have one?” Lisa asked.

“Of course. All this belongs to me.”

“Then you can check, can't you?”

Arseny looked at the ring of keys in his hand. For the first time in years, they seemed less like proof of his authority and more like an invitation to open something.

Chapter Ten. An Inconvenient Answer

Reluctantly, Arseny led the children and Mikhail Antonovich into the Tower's archive. Rows of identical folders stood beneath a sign that read “EVERYTHING HAS BEEN ACCOUNTED FOR.”

The folders of weather forecasts were thick. The folder on inspections of the old channel was thin. It held a single page: “CHANNEL CLOSED. NEW SYSTEM SUFFICIENT.”

“Who checked that?” Lisa asked.

Arseny searched for a signature. There wasn't one.

“My father approved the project.”

“But who checked the calculations and the condition of the tunnel?”

“I don't know.”

Three small words. Arseny said them as if he had picked up a heavy suitcase for the first time in his life.

Lisa suggested going underground to look. Mikhail Antonovich stopped her.

“Not alone, not without permission, and certainly not when a storm is approaching. Asking questions does not make you invincible.”

Vera Petrovna soon arrived with her colleague. They spread out the drawings and asked to see the records of the most recent inspections.

“There's no signature here,” Lisa said.

“That means we don't yet know who was responsible for checking it,” said Vera Petrovna. “But even a signature can't take the place of an inspection. We need calculations, dates, and records of what was found. And we need to know what's changed since then.”

She compared the old map with the new plans. Her colleague telephoned the town maintenance service to check

their information. Then an emergency crew arrived. The children were not allowed into the tunnel. They stayed with Mikhail Antonovich in a room above the archive.

Waiting turned out to be duller than investigating. Lisa had time to draw three question marks and an angry teapot in the margin of a page. Slava brought water. Arseny kept going to the door, but he didn't hurry the people on the other side.

When Vera Petrovna returned, there were new notes on her drawings. The old drainage route really had been left out of the new plans, and parts of the replacement system had long

been due for repair. They hadn't found this out from the sound beneath a grating or the water on a tray. The specialists had compared the records with what they checked on site.

“What happens now?” Arseny asked.

“Now we stop pretending we know everything,” said Vera Petrovna. “We warn people, check safe evacuation routes, and prepare a temporary way to divert water. We can use the section of the old route we've checked.”

“But the Festival of the Great Answer is tomorrow!”

“Water doesn't read calendars,” Slava observed.

Arseny could have forbidden anyone to announce the uncomfortable news. His family name stood on the building. His money could buy new screens, and screens could display any soothing words he liked. He had already opened his mouth to say, “That's not how things are done,” when he looked at Vera Petrovna's new notes. Beside the calculations were the names of streets where people lived.

“Make the announcement,” he said. “And show me how I can help.”

It was the first question Arseny had asked without hoping for an answer he already knew.

That evening Lisa lay awake for a long time. The festival flags stirred outside her window. The nearest said “ALL IS CLEAR,” but it kept curling round until it said only “ALL.”

Her father sat beside her bed.

“Are you frightened?” he asked.

Lisa nodded.

He didn't tell her there was nothing to be frightened of. Instead, he explained where they would meet if they had to leave home and showed her the bag he

had packed. Then Lisa asked him to put the biscuit tin in it.

“It has questions in it,” she explained. “They're light.”

The tin wasn't all that light. Her father moved it to the bottom of the bag.

“What if I ask completely the wrong thing?” Lisa said.

“Then we'll work out what you meant to ask.”

She lay listening to him zip up the bag and thought about the blocks on the tray. It was good that real houses were more complicated than blocks. It was bad that this made things more complicated.

“Will you stay a little longer?”

“I will.”

That question needed neither a notebook nor four different signs. Her father simply sat there until she fell asleep.

In the margins: 17 · 18

Chapter Eleven. The Festival of the Great Answer

The next morning the festival was cancelled. Garlands still hung across the square, proclaiming “ALL IS CLEAR” and “NO NEED TO WORRY.” Nobody had had time to take them down. Beneath them, workers stacked sandbags and put up signs pointing towards higher streets. The decorations looked rather peculiar together.

At first there was a light rain. Then the rain stopped being light. The river beneath the stone square roared as though a giant

who had kept quiet for years had finally decided to speak.

One of the Tower's screens was still repeating an old automatic announcement: “SITUATION NORMAL.”

A message came from the engineers below: “WATER LEVEL RISING.” The next screen declared: “DATA DO NOT MATCH FORECAST.”

“And the forecast doesn't match the data,” Lisa pointed out.

Arseny ordered the old announcements to be removed. In their place came messages from the town emergency service: which streets were closed, where help was available,

and when to expect the next update.

Then everyone got to work. Vera Petrovna directed the rescue workers and engineers. Grown-ups helped people who found it difficult to walk. In the dry school hall, Slava arranged the books that adults had already carried out of the library basement. Lisa brought clean water to families arriving at the school, delivered notes, and kept asking who else needed help. The children were kept well away from the flooded streets.

Arseny opened warehouses that had previously been reserved for grand occasions and turned their rooms over to families from

flooded streets. He did not attempt to instruct the engineers, because he had finally understood that owning something was not the same as knowing how it worked.

When water covered part of the square, a message appeared on the Tower's screen: “WHEN WILL ALL THE WATER BE GONE? UNKNOWN.”

People froze. They had not seen that word on an official notice for so long that they mistook it for a threat.

Lisa saw the word on the screen at school.

“It's not the end,” she said to the people in the hall. “It's where the work begins!”

Out in the streets, people asked, “Where should we go?” The stewards answered, “To the school, along the marked route.” Someone asked, “How do we get there with a wheelchair?” Somebody knew the marked route with no steps. Then a person asked about an elderly neighbour who lived alone. Someone else knew her address.

Questions passed from one person to another. Each new question gave someone a new thing they could do together.

By nightfall, the rain had eased. The engineers had safely redirected part of the flow along the temporary route they had prepared. The town was wet, exhausted, and very much alive. Only part of the square was visible from the school steps. Lisa couldn't see the channel. But she could see that people were no longer arriving every minute, and that Vera Petrovna had at last sat down and drunk her cold tea.

On the great clock, the hand marked “TOMORROW” finally moved forward.

Mikhail Antonovich watched it without a word. Perhaps someone had merely repaired the mechanism. Or perhaps

tomorrow always begins when someone admits that today is not fully understood.

Chapter Twelve. Whose Fault Was It?

The next morning Clearford looked as if a very large, very ill-mannered whale had walked through town and forgotten to wipe its flippers.

People argued in the square. Some blamed the Tower. Others blamed the engineers. Still others blamed the weather. Someone said it was all the fault of the little girl who never stopped asking questions and therefore attracted trouble.

“The rain didn't ask Lisa's permission,” said Aunt Rita. “And she wasn't in charge of the pipes.”

Lisa still wanted to shout back. But even more than that, she wanted to understand why the system hadn't been repaired in time. She didn't know the answer and wasn't going to make one up.

“First, let's find out what happened,” she said. “Then we can decide who was responsible for what. But right now, who needs help?”

That question proved more useful than all the accusations combined.

The next day, the school opened a temporary workshop. People dried books there, made signs for safe paths, and sorted donated belongings. Mrs. Sergeyeva

arrived carrying her class register and asked something unexpected:

“Why did we never teach children to ask questions whose answers we teachers didn't know ourselves?”

“Because they're difficult to give marks for,” Lisa suggested.

“Possibly,” said the teacher. “Let's see if we can invent another way.”

Arseny Velsky brought money for repairs and suggested putting his name above the new entrance. Mikhail Antonovich wondered whether the wall might instead carry the names of everyone who

had helped. Arseny considered this and agreed.

“But how will I know it's really my project?” he asked.

“Come and help carry planks tomorrow,” Slava suggested. “You'll find out.”

Arseny came. The planks were heavier than folders of ready-made answers. On the other hand, not one of them cared whose name was written over the door.

A few days later, Arseny reached the workshop earlier than usual. There was dried paint on his sleeve, and he kept trying to cover the spot with his hand. It was only a small spot, but Arseny

felt it entered the room ahead of him.

Slava sat by the window with a paper plane. He had bent one wing a little more than the other.

“That'll make it fly crookedly,” said Arseny.

“Let's see.”

The plane flew in a wide curve and landed by the door.

Arseny opened his mouth. He was about to explain that this was exactly what he had predicted. But Slava had already brought out another plane, with matching wings. That one turned too, only the other way.

“A draught?” Arseny asked.

“Maybe.”

They shut the door. Now the planes turned differently.

Arseny sat on a low stool with his knees almost under his chin. It wasn't a comfortable place to give orders from, but it did give him a good view of the plane on the floor.

“Why does one turn this way and the other that way?”

“I don't know yet,” said Slava. “I changed the wing. But the paper's different too.”

Arseny rubbed the paint spot on his sleeve.

“I can buy you some paper that's all the same. Very good paper.”

“This is good paper too. It's just different.”

Arseny looked at the sheets. On the back of one were the words “FESTIVAL OF THE GREAT ANSWER.” The other was an old notice about a missing umbrella. According to a note at the bottom, the umbrella had been found back in the spring.

“What should I do, then?”

Slava handed him a sheet.

“Try folding one.”

Arseny's first plane looked like an envelope that had changed its mind about holding letters. His second looked like a very angry hat. Slava didn't take the paper

away and do it for him. He showed Arseny the fold on his own sheet, then waited.

By the time Lisa arrived, four planes and one hat lay on the floor.

“Is this the post office?” she asked.

“An airfield,” said Slava.

“Does the hat fly too?”

“So far it only falls,” said Arseny.

He surprised himself by saying it without making an excuse.

Lisa wanted to launch everything at once. Slava suggested clearing the way first. People were coming into the workshop carrying

boxes, so they picked up the sheets, and for a little while the planes had to be ordinary paper again.

Arseny stood up from the stool. He had half an hour before an important meeting. Once, he would certainly have said something to sum things up: the experiment had succeeded, the results were useful, the important thing was to organise the work properly.

Now he asked:

“Will you be here tomorrow?”

“After school,” said Slava.

“I'll bring my plane. If I manage to fold one.”

“Come even if you don't,” said Lisa.

Arseny nodded and went to the door. Just before leaving, he looked back.

“Is the spot very noticeable?”

Lisa looked at his sleeve.

“Not from the stool.”

Arseny laughed. Then he lowered his hand and stopped covering up the paint.

Chapter Thirteen. The House of Unasked Questions

The old Club of the Curious reopened as the House of Unasked Questions.

A great board stood near the door. Anyone could write down something they didn't know. It filled up almost at once: “Why does bread go stale?” “Can a street be comfortable for everybody?” “Where have the fireflies gone?” “Why is apologising sometimes so hard?”

Beside it hung four smaller signs: “I SAW,” “I WAS TOLD,” “I THINK,” and “I CHECKED.”

Mikhail Antonovich insisted they should never be confused with one another.

The House had rules. Nobody was allowed to try dangerous experiments on themselves or other people. Nobody could pry into someone else's private life without permission. Making mistakes and changing your mind were allowed. If you didn't know, you said, “I don't know.” If you did know, you explained how. And if someone asked a question too soon, you could answer, “Let's work it out first.”

Lisa's mother and father began coming in the evenings. At first they sat quietly. Then her father asked whether he might finally

reassemble Grandfather's clock. Her mother wanted to know why some paints faded faster than others.

Lisa was astonished. Grown-ups hadn't lost the ability to ask questions after all. They had simply got into the habit of hiding it beneath work, tiredness, and the word “later.”

In the corner of the large hall hung a drawing of the colourful wall, which Lisa had brought from home. Beneath it someone had written: “YOU CAN CHANGE THE WORLD. ASK PEOPLE BEFORE YOU CHANGE THEIRS.”

One morning a question appeared on the board: “IF I

FORGET A DREAM, WHERE DOES IT GO?”

Plenty of space had been left underneath.

By lunchtime someone had written: “Into your head.” Somebody else had added: “But it was in your head already.” A third person had drawn a pillow with a pocket.

Lisa stood in front of the board, thinking. Perhaps you didn't forget the whole dream. A feeling might stay. Or a colour. Or the certainty that there had been a hippopotamus in it, though every witness except you was asleep.

She was about to write this down when a girl in a yellow scarf stopped beside her.

“That's my question,” the girl said.

“There are three answers already.”

“I saw. But I'm still wondering.”

Lisa moved over so the girl could see better.

A man who had been helping to arrange the tables came up.

“Isn't it time to rub this out?” he asked. “The board's getting full. We've talked about it now.”

The girl took hold of the end of her scarf.

“I haven't finished asking.”

The man looked at the cloth in his hand, then at the board.

“Then I'll find another board,” he said.

There wasn't another board just then. But in the cupboard they found a wide roll of paper and hung it beside the first one. The bottom edge refused to lie flat and kept rolling the new questions into a tube.

Tikhon brought two drawings and took his time choosing where to pin them. In one, the “Why?” bird was flying over water with a boot in its beak. The other showed “I don't know”: a little boat, still tied to the bank.

“Are those for the board?” Lisa asked.

“They can go beside it. Not over the question.”

He pinned them up himself. Then he sat down to draw something else and turned the paper over when Lisa came too close. She stepped back. A little later, he chose to show her: the pillow with the pocket was now sailing in the boat.

Lisa laughed. So did the girl in the yellow scarf. There was still no answer about the dream, but the pillow in the boat looked splendid.

Towards evening Lisa took out her old tin. Inside lay scraps of

paper of all sizes. Some had yellowed; some were stained with paint. The very first still asked where yesterday went.

She meant to copy it into a big notebook, then changed her mind. The little slip fitted nicely in the palm of her hand.

Slava settled beside her and laid out some paper for planes. Lisa told him about the dream. He was quiet for a while.

“Are you thinking of an answer?” she asked.

“No. Trying to remember what I dreamed.”

“What was it?”

“I think I was a staircase.”

“Leading where?”

Slava thought some more.

“That's the bit I've forgotten.”

Lisa pushed a clean sheet towards him. He could write a question on it. Or draw a staircase. Or do nothing with it yet.

Slava took the pencil. Lisa looked out of the window. An evening cloud had got stuck between the rooftops, and she wanted to know who was going to fetch it. She didn't hurry to write that down. The cloud was beautiful, and for the moment they had only one pencil.

The next day, the question about the dream was still on the board. New ones had appeared beside it. Nobody promised to have everything settled by Friday.

The House arranged a meeting for Friday all the same.

Next door stood the former Tower of Answers, now the Library of Answers. Its cards still helped people find pharmacies and check train timetables. Only now each carried one small additional line: “Checked on this date. May change. Please ask the next question.”

The town did not become perfect. People still argued out of stubbornness, believed beautiful

mistakes, and confused loud voices with evidence. But there was now somewhere they could go and try to work things out together.

And that was no small thing.

In the margins: 19 · 20 · 21 · 22 · 23

Epilogue. The Smallest Question

Years passed. Lisa grew up. People often asked what she had become: a scientist, an artist, a teacher, an inventor? She answered that she was learning a little of everything, but most of all she loved to notice where the ready-made answers ran out.

One day a little girl was brought to see her. The child was holding a broken alarm clock and looking so guilty that she might have stopped the entire world.

“I wanted to find out where yesterday goes,” the girl

confessed. “They said I'd understand when I grew up.”

Lisa carefully took the clock. Something inside gave a tiny clink.

“You know,” she said, “I once looked for yesterday inside a clock too. I didn't find it.”

“So you know the right answer now?”

Lisa smiled.

“I know some of it. Some parts I still don't know. But first I'd like to ask you a question.”

“What question?”

“Would you like to find out together?”

The little girl considered this and nodded.

They spread a towel across the table. They found a screwdriver. They invited a clockmaker and prepared a little box for the pieces. And beside it they laid a fresh sheet of paper, because they already knew this would not end with a single question.

In the beginning was the Word.

And the Word was a Question.

And then, at last, somebody said:

“Let's find out together.”

The end of the second book. Not the end of questions.

In the margins: 24

In the Margins: The Question Tree

A separate conversation in the margins. Read it straight through, or return to it from the chapters.

> *I planted a question. Not in the ground—in the margin. Will you water it?*

Back to the story

> *I did. Not with water, but with another question. Now we have two sprouts.*

Back to the story

> *What if an answer is a question wearing a mask?*

Back to the story

Then our tree will never have a top. Just branches. I like that.

Back to the story

I'll draw a clock on this branch. Why does it tick? In a mechanical clock, a little wheel is held back, then moves a tiny step. The parts click. I'll ask Mikhail Antonovich to show us how it works.

Back to the story

My branch grows slowly. It's still thinking about which way to go.

Back to the story

Mine grows fast. It's already tangled up with the next one. Help me untangle it?

Back to the story

Let's leave it for now. I'll draw mine alongside. There's room for both.

Back to the story

Why do some paints fade faster than others? Light can change their colour, but some resist it better. Let's find an old picture. Does the colour under the frame match the rest?

Back to the story

I drew another line. It went down.

Back to the story

Slava, you've broken the tree! I thought we were drawing the branches upwards.

Back to the story

Wait. That's what I thought. What were you trying to draw?

Back to the story

A root. In our tree drawing, questions grow downwards too.

Back to the story

What's down there?

Back to the story

The things we haven't asked yet.

Back to the story

Then let it grow. I shouldn't have said "broken". May I add a little root beside it?

Back to the story

Yes. I'll draw a bubble on mine. Why do baking soda and lemon juice fizz? When they react, they make a gas called carbon dioxide. That's what fills the bubbles.

Back to the story

We never finished this branch. At first I wanted to rub it out. Now I don't. Let's leave it.

Back to the story

And here goes a paper plane. I wonder how it will fly if we fold

one wing differently. Let's write down our guess first. Then compare a few flights.

Back to the story

I've already written, "It will fly in a circle." Oh. That's only what I think so far. I'll move it to the guesses.

Back to the story

We'll write what we notice separately. If we see it differently, we'll watch again. Shall we give the plane a name too?

Back to the story

"The Branch with Wings." I've stopped counting the branches.

Our tree doesn't even have apples. I still like it.

Back to the story

Me too. Shall we water it with another question tomorrow?

Back to the story

What will grow from your question?